the landscape and the blazing sun high in the sky. For the traveller who first experienced the endless plains of northern Hindustan, the heat was a feral presence, constant and unabating. To travel in India, warned the Portuguese missionary and traveller, Father Sebastien Manrique in 1640, was to be ‘heated by ague or by the heat which the titanic and glowing planet causes’.

But there were, indeed, two harvests, one in autumn and another in spring. In the autumn, crops such as millets, pulses (lobia, moth, and moong), sesame, and sugarcane were harvested. The spring crops were wheat, barley, chickpeas, and masoor. And there was rice, in Bengal, around Delhi, and in parts of what is now Haryana. Cash crops included cotton, sugarcane, indigo, and opium as well as black pepper and ginger in Kerala. Wells and ponds irrigated the fields, from which water was drawn using a so-called Persian wheel worked by oxen or a simple pulley and yoke using camels. Where irrigation was not available, peasants waited for thunderstorms and for the monsoon. Villagers kept cows and buffalo and sold dairy products such as milk, yoghurt, ghee, and meat in the town markets. And while most people lived in the countryside, an unexpectedly large number lived in the great towns and cities. Calculating the population of the country in the sixteenth century is difficult as there was nothing even approaching a census; by 1600 it was estimated at 100 million by W. H. Moreland, a nineteenth-century British historian of India, and 130–140 million by historian Shireen Moosvi,[*] accounting for 24 per cent of the world population. According to historian Irfan Habib, about 15 per cent of the population lived in cities, the larger ones teeming with 250,000 to 500,000 people.

Even though agriculture was the mainstay of the peasantry, a number of people were also engaged in the manufacturing sector, which exported goods to western Asia and Europe. The products were also consumed by the large domestic market in the towns. ‘Cotton textiles (calico, dyed and printed), silk fabrics, indigo and damascened steel’ were some of the prized products being manufactured in the country.

The villagers lived in simple, nearly bare huts, which were notoriously impermanent. Famine, war, pestilence, or migration for work could force villagers to leave their homes, a small bag of belongings balanced on their heads, while the huts were reclaimed by the elements. Even in the cities, buildings often fell into genteel ruin once abandoned.